

Now, Package Management is Intelligent by Design

Check out PackageKit, a distribution-neutral software manager.



In the good old days, the way you learnt about Linux was to build your own distribution and of course, design your own package manager as well. After all, what was the point of having your own distribution if you didn't even write a custom package manager, right? As a result of that, package managers, packaging formats and dependency resolvers are a dime a dozen these days, in Linux. While most of them are as obscure as some of the distributions themselves, there are enough popular variations.

While we hail this as freedom and choice, this does have a cost associated with it. Users have to keep relearning the differences between software management tools. Not just distribution hoppers but also systems administrators who have to deal with different distributions all the time. Many applications developers would love to install additional software or content on demand instead of worrying about

differences between distributions. Fortunately, *yum install foo* is not conceptually different from *apt-get install foo*. It is possible to abstract away the differences and provide a distribution-neutral interface for both users as well as developers.

Lo and behold! Enter PackageKit

Richard Hughes, a Red Hat developer, the maintainer of GNOME Power Manager and a contributor to other software such as HAL and DeviceKit, took a look at the landscape of graphical software managers in Linux a couple of years back and found that while each of them had their own advantages, they were essentially reinventing the wheel with their own quirks. And since distributions have a long history of investment in their own packaging tools, they weren't going to give up easily.

He decided to develop PackageKit from scratch in a distribution-independent way.